

5.1b

An introduction to business correspondence

Worksheet

B These statements refer to modern business letters. Mark them True (T) or False (F).

- 1 At the top of the letter the order is: reference, receiver's address, date.
- 2 *Our Ref.* often contains the initials of the typist.
- 3 Today is 12 June 1998. In Europe you write 12.06.98 and in the USA you write 06.12.98.
- 4 It is normal to write *Mr J. Smith* in the first line of the receiver's address, and underneath to write *Dear Mr Smith* without the initial.
- 5 The subject heading usually comes before *Dear Mr Smith*.
- 6 There is one clear line space between every section at the top of the letter.
- 7 In modern business letters *Dear Mr Smith* and *Yours sincerely* are followed by a comma.
- 8 When you address a person by name (*Dear Mr. Smith*), you close with *Yours sincerely*. When you don't know the person's name (*Dear Sir/Madam*), you close with *Yours faithfully*.
- 9 American letters often close with *Sincerely* or *Yours truly*.
- 10 When writing to a colleague/contact you know – but who is not a personal friend – you can close the letter with all of these: *Kind regards*, *With best wishes*, *Best wishes*.
- 11 These days many women prefer to be known as *Ms* rather than *Miss* or *Mrs*.
- 12 A typist will often put one space after a comma and two spaces after a full stop.
- 13 *pp* is used when somebody signs for another person.
- 14 Formal language is often used in modern business letters to show respect.

C Write *Letter*, *Fax* or *e-mail* next to each of these descriptions.

- 1 This is used in routine day-to-day communication where the correct choice of words is not so important. The subject title is important to help the reader find it in the files later. The style is informal and very direct. The content is very short as only the basic information is mentioned.
- 2 This is used for those situations where the writer wants to make a good impression or where the correct choice of words is important (eg for a first contact with a possible new customer or for making a complaint). The style is careful and polite and there is much use of standard expressions.
- 3 This is used for some day-to-day communication, particularly to transmit copies of documents that are not in electronic form. The style is intermediate and depends on who will read it. Informal, direct language can be mixed with some longer, standard expressions.

Write *Letter* or *e-mail* next to each of these.

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| 4a longer sentences | b shorter sentences |
| 5a much use of abbreviations | b less use of abbreviations |
| 6a words of Latin origin
(verify, inform, return) | b words of Anglo-Saxon origin
(check, tell, send back) |
| 7a ideas presented politely and carefully | b ideas presented simply and directly |
| 8a much use of standard expressions | b less use of standard expressions |

D Write a short letter in your name to the Language School/organization/trainer whose course you are now following. The letter is to ask for information about courses, dates, prices etc.

When you have finished, write an e-mail for the same reason.

